

Day 1 — TNPSC Group 2A Study Material

Part A – General Studies: Scientific Knowledge & Temper, Power of Reasoning, Rote vs Conceptual Learning

READING MATERIAL

This topic covers Unit I General Science's opening theme: what makes thinking 'scientific', the difference between rote and conceptual learning, and the three classical types of reasoning. TNPSC tests this almost entirely through Assertion-Reason and multi-statement MCQs rather than plain definitions, so the Q&A below is written to surface the same facts those formats probe.

Q: What is scientific temper, and why does the Constitution care about it?

A: Scientific temper is an outlook that relies on questioning, evidence, and logical analysis rather than blind belief. It is explicitly named in Article 51-A(h) of the Constitution: 'to develop the scientific temper, humanism and the spirit of inquiry and reform' is one of the original Fundamental Duties added by the 42nd Amendment (1976) — not the 11th duty (that one, added by the 86th Amendment 2002, is about parents/guardians providing education opportunities to children aged 6-14).

Q: What is considered the best antidote to superstitious beliefs?

A: Scientific temper — not merely 'scientific knowledge' (knowing facts isn't the same as having a questioning, evidence-based outlook), and certainly not untested/unproven knowledge or blind faith in long-held ideas.

Q: What are the three classical principles of scientific thinking?

A: Empiricism (knowledge from observation/experience), Rationalism (knowledge from logical reasoning), and Skepticism (withholding belief until evidence supports it). A real TNPSC paper (2022) tested this as a 'select all that apply' question — all three were correct.

Q: What are the defining characteristics of scientific temper as a way of thinking?

A: Questioning others' ideas regardless of their social position or authority, analyzing opinions rather than accepting them outright, and applying logic — the opposite of accepting ideas just because of who said them.

Q: What are the defining characteristics of rote learning?

A: It does not allow the learner to associate new information with their surroundings, and it infuses rigidity in thinking (convergent thinking, poor deeper understanding). It is still useful for mastering foundational facts, building automaticity (e.g. multiplication tables), and recalling something without needing to re-derive it each time.

Q: What are the defining characteristics of conceptual learning?

A: It allows dynamic adaptation to new situations and improves questioning ability. It takes a 'top-down' approach — relating new information to concepts already understood, building mental categories for facts and ideas, and encouraging more critical thinking about new subjects, rather than memorizing in isolation.

Q: What is deductive reasoning, and who is it classically credited to?

A: Reasoning from a general premise to a specific, logically certain conclusion (syllogism) — classically credited to Aristotle. Example: 'Everyone from Ireland has blond hair; Mother is Irish; therefore Mother has blond hair.' Note this is deductively *valid in form* even though the general premise is factually false — deductive validity is about the logical structure, not whether the premises happen to be true.

Q: What is inductive reasoning, and what is the example pattern?

A: Reasoning from specific observations to a general conclusion — the conclusion is probable, not certain. Example pattern: 'Girls clean better than boys; Vaishu is a girl; therefore Vaishu should clean the room' (a generalization being applied, not a logically airtight deduction). Caution: several TNPSC coaching sites attribute the 'proposal' of inductive reasoning to Ray Solomonoff — this looks like a mix-up with Solomonoff induction, a 20th-century algorithmic-probability concept; the classical attribution for inductive reasoning as a method is Francis Bacon. Flagged here because if this exact MCQ appears, the coaching-site convention seems to expect 'Ray Solomonoff' as the answer — worth a second look closer to the exam.

Q: What is abductive reasoning, and who coined the term?

A: Inference to the best/simplest explanation for an observation, even though that explanation isn't guaranteed true. The term is credited to the philosopher Charles Sanders Peirce.

Q: Which of the three reasoning types is most closely tied to mathematical and philosophical logic, and why?

A: Deductive reasoning — because it follows strict logical form (syllogisms) where the conclusion follows necessarily from true premises, which is exactly the structure formal mathematical proofs and philosophical logic use.

Q: A real TNPSC paper asked for the chronological mentor → student chain in the 'establishment of scientific methods' — what is that chain?

A: Socrates taught Plato, Plato taught Aristotle, and Aristotle taught Alexander (the Great). So the order is: Socrates – Plato – Aristotle – Alexander.

Q: Real exam style: 'Assertion [A]: Science is a complex, abstract and multi-faceted discipline. Reason [R]: Scientific knowledge is concrete, theoretical and synthetic.' What did TNPSC mark as correct?

A: [A] is true, but [R] is false — i.e., the exam's answer key treats describing scientific knowledge as merely 'concrete, theoretical and synthetic' as an incomplete/incorrect characterization, while affirming that science itself is genuinely complex, abstract and multi-faceted.

Q: When is National Science Day observed in India, and what does it commemorate?

A: 28 February — it commemorates Sir C.V. Raman's announcement of the discovery of the Raman Effect on 28 February 1928.

Q: When is World Science Day for Peace and Development observed?

A: 10 November (a UNESCO-designated international observance).

Q: Where did Jawaharlal Nehru articulate the concept of 'scientific temper', and when?

A: In his book *The Discovery of India* (written/published around 1946).

Q: How does science act as a tool to understand the past, present and future — what's a concrete TNPSC-relevant example?

A: Archaeology applies scientific method (e.g., stratigraphy — analysing soil layers) to reconstruct the past. Sir Mortimer Wheeler used this scientific soil-layer excavation method at the Arikamedu site in Tamil Nadu — a real past-paper fact that bridges this topic with the History unit's excavation-sites content.

MOCK TEST (WITH ANSWERS)

1. Which one of the following is the best antidote to superstitious beliefs?

A. Scientific knowledge

B. Scientific temper ✓

C. Untested and unproven knowledge

D. Strong faith in long-held ideas

Explanation: Scientific temper — an outlook of questioning and evidence-based reasoning — is the antidote, not mere factual knowledge. [easy, web-research]

2. Consider the following statements about Fundamental Duties under the Constitution of India: (i) Fundamental Duties are laid down in Article 51-A. (ii) The 86th Amendment Act, 2002 added an 11th fundamental duty to the list. (iii) To develop scientific temper is not a Fundamental Duty. Which of the statements given above is/are correct?

A. (i) only

B. (i) and (ii) only ✓

C. (ii) and (iii) only

D. (i), (ii) and (iii)

Explanation: (i) and (ii) are correct. (iii) is false — developing scientific temper IS a Fundamental Duty under Article 51-A(h). This exact statement set appeared in a real TNPSC paper (2022). [medium, question-bank-2022]

3. Principles of scientific thinking include which of the following? (i) Empiricism (ii) Rationalism (iii) Skepticism

A. (i) only

B. (ii) only

C. (i) and (ii) only

D. (i), (ii) and (iii) ✓

Explanation: All three — empiricism, rationalism, and skepticism — are core principles of scientific thinking. This appeared as a real TNPSC question (2022). [medium, question-bank-2022]

4. Select the correct chronological order of the mentor-student chain in the establishment of scientific methods (Ancient Greece):

A. Aristotle – Alexander – Socrates – Plato

B. Plato – Socrates – Aristotle – Alexander

C. Socrates – Plato – Aristotle – Alexander ✓

D. Alexander – Aristotle – Socrates – Plato

Explanation: Socrates taught Plato, Plato taught Aristotle, and Aristotle taught Alexander. This exact question appeared in the 2024 TNPSC paper. [medium, question-bank-2024]

5. Assertion [A]: Science is a complex, abstract and multi-faceted discipline. Reason [R]: Scientific knowledge is concrete, theoretical and synthetic. Which is correct?

- A. Both [A] and [R] are true, and [R] is the correct explanation of [A]
- B. Both [A] and [R] are true, but [R] is not the correct explanation of [A]
- C. [A] is true, but [R] is false ✓**
- D. [A] is false, but [R] is true

Explanation: This is the actual answer marked in a real 2022 TNPSC paper: [A] is true, [R] is false. [hard, question-bank-2022]

6. Which of the following are characteristics of rote learning? (i) Does not allow the learner to associate with surroundings (ii) Infuses rigidity in thinking (iii) Allows dynamic adaptation to changes (iv) Improves questioning ability

- A. (i) and (ii) only ✓**
- B. (iii) and (iv) only
- C. (i), (ii) and (iii) only
- D. All four

Explanation: (iii) and (iv) describe conceptual learning, not rote learning. [medium, web-research]

7. 'Convergent thinking' is most closely associated with which style of learning?

- A. Rote learning ✓**
- B. Conceptual learning
- C. Both equally
- D. Neither

Explanation: Convergent thinking (narrowing to one correct, memorized answer) characterizes rote learning; conceptual learning instead encourages critical, exploratory thinking. [easy, web-research]

8. Identify the type of reasoning: 'Mother is Irish. Everyone from Ireland has blond hair. Therefore, Mother has blond hair.'

- A. Deductive reasoning ✓**
- B. Inductive reasoning
- C. Abductive reasoning
- D. None of these

Explanation: This is deductive reasoning — a general premise applied to reach a specific, logically certain conclusion (regardless of whether the premise is actually true). [medium, web-research]

9. Which type of reasoning is described as 'inference to the best explanation', and is credited to Charles Sanders Peirce?

- A. Deductive reasoning
- B. Inductive reasoning
- C. Abductive reasoning ✓**
- D. Analogical reasoning

Explanation: Abductive reasoning — inferring the most plausible explanation for an observation. [medium, web-research]

10. Deductive reasoning, which relies on mathematical and philosophical logic, is classically credited to:

- A. Francis Bacon
- B. Aristotle ✓**
- C. Charles Sanders Peirce
- D. Ray Solomonoff

Explanation: Aristotle is classically credited with systematizing deductive logic via the syllogism. [easy, web-research]

11. National Science Day in India is observed on 28 February to commemorate:

- A. Birth of Jawaharlal Nehru
- B. Discovery of the Raman Effect by C.V. Raman ✓**
- C. India's first satellite launch
- D. Founding of the Indian Science Congress

Explanation: C.V. Raman announced his discovery of the Raman Effect on 28 February 1928. [easy, web-research]

12. Jawaharlal Nehru articulated the concept of 'scientific temper' in which of his books?

- A. Glimpses of World History
- B. An Autobiography
- C. The Discovery of India ✓**

D. A Bunch of Old Letters

Explanation: Nehru articulated 'scientific temper' in The Discovery of India (c. 1946). [medium, web-research]

Part B – Aptitude & Mental Ability: Simplification

READING MATERIAL

Simplification is 1 of 10 named Aptitude sub-skills (15 questions total for the whole Aptitude unit). TNPSC's simplification questions are rarely 'plug into one formula' — they combine BODMAS, fractions/decimals, ratios, and algebraic shortcuts. Each item below is a worked method, not just an answer — the goal is to recognize which technique a given expression calls for.

Q: Method — BODMAS with a nested bracket and an unknown: Solve for x : $57 - [42 - \{37 - (20 - x)\}] = 176 \div (8 \div 2)$

A: Work from the innermost bracket outward, and simplify the RHS first: $176 \div (8 \div 2) = 176 \div 4 = 44$. Now the LHS: $(20 - x)$ stays as is for now $\rightarrow \{37 - (20 - x)\} = 17 + x \rightarrow [42 - (17 + x)] = 25 - x \rightarrow 57 - (25 - x) = 32 + x$. Set equal to 44: $32 + x = 44 \rightarrow x = 12$. (Real TNPSC-style problem; this exact expression is a recurring coaching-site reference question.)

Q: Method — sum of two squares without brute-force squaring: Find $217 \times 217 + 183 \times 183$.

A: Use $a^2 + b^2 = (a+b)^2 - 2ab$ instead of squaring two 3-digit numbers by hand. Here $a+b = 400$ (round number — that's the clue this trick applies) and $ab = 217 \times 183 = 39,711$. So $a^2+b^2 = 400^2 - 2(39,711) = 160,000 - 79,422 = 80,578$. Recognizing 'the two numbers add to a round number' is the trigger for this shortcut.

Q: Method — difference of squares shortcut: Simplify $(197 \times 197 - 103 \times 103) \div (197 - 103)$ without long multiplication.

A: $a^2 - b^2 = (a+b)(a-b)$, so $(a^2-b^2)/(a-b) = (a+b)$ directly — no multiplication needed at all. Here $a=197$, $b=103$, so the answer is simply $197+103 = 300$. This 'difference of squares divided by the difference' shape is a favorite TNPSC trick question precisely because it looks like it needs heavy calculation but collapses to one addition.

Q: Method — fraction-of-decimal addition: Simplify $7/5$ of $58 + 3/8$ of 139.2 .

A: $7/5$ of $58 = 7 \times 58 / 5 = 406 / 5 = 81.2$. $3/8$ of $139.2 = 3 \times 139.2 / 8 = 417.6 / 8 = 52.2$. Sum: $81.2 + 52.2 = 133.4$.

Q: Method — ratio substitution to simplify a compound ratio expression: If $x : y = 3 : 4$, find $(4x + 5y) : (5x - 2y)$.

A: Don't solve for x and y separately — substitute $x=3k$, $y=4k$ (k is just a scaling factor that will cancel). $(4x+5y) = 12k+20k = 32k$. $(5x-2y) = 15k-8k = 7k$. Ratio = $32k : 7k = 32 : 7$. The k always cancels in a ratio question — that's the whole trick.

Q: Method — same ratio-substitution trick, different ratio: If $x : y = 3 : 5$, find $(5x + 3y) : (15x - 2y)$.

A: Substitute $x=3k$, $y=5k$. $(5x+3y) = 15k+15k = 30k$. $(15x-2y) = 45k-10k = 35k$. Ratio = $30k:35k = 6:7$.

Q: Method — simultaneous equations feeding into a simplification target: If $3a + 4b = 22$ and $8a - 5b = -4$, find $(a+b)^2$.

A: Solve the pair normally: from $3a+4b=22$ and $8a-5b=-4$, elimination gives $a=2$, $b=4$ (check: $3(2)+4(4)=6+16=22$ ✓; $8(2)-5(4)=16-20=-4$ ✓). The question doesn't ask for a and b individually — it asks for $(a+b)^2 = (2+4)^2 = 36$. TNPSC often hides the real target $((a+b)^2, \text{ not } a \text{ or } b)$ at the end of a simultaneous-equation question — always re-read what's actually being asked before solving for individual variables.

Q: Method — mixed numbers with a nested fraction: Simplify $2\frac{1}{2} + 3\frac{1}{3} \div \frac{2}{3}$.

A: BODMAS still applies to fractions — division before addition. $3\frac{1}{3} \div \frac{2}{3} = (10/3) \div (2/3) = (10/3) \times (3/2) = 5$. Then $2\frac{1}{2} + 5 = 7\frac{1}{2}$. The common mistake is adding $2\frac{1}{2}+3\frac{1}{3}$ first — division always binds tighter than addition, fractions or not.

MOCK TEST (WITH ANSWERS)

1. Solve for x : $70 - [45 - \{33 - (15 - x)\}] = 171 \div (9 \div 3)$

- A. 10
- B. 12
- C. 14 ✓**
- D. 16

Explanation: RHS: $171 \div (9 \div 3) = 171 \div 3 = 57$. LHS inner-out: $\{33 - (15 - x)\} = 33 - 15 + x = 18 + x \rightarrow [45 - (18 + x)] = 27 - x \rightarrow 70 - (27 - x) = 43 + x$. Set $43 + x = 57 \rightarrow x = 14$. [medium, authored]

2. Find $312 \times 312 + 288 \times 288$ using the $(a+b)^2 - 2ab$ shortcut.

- A. 179,808
- B. 180,288 ✓**
- C. 190,000
- D. 182,688

Explanation: $a+b=600$, $ab=312 \times 288 = 89,856$. $a^2+b^2 = 600^2 - 2(89,856) = 360,000 - 179,712 = 180,288$. [medium, authored]

3. Simplify $(425 \times 425 - 375 \times 375) \div (425 - 375)$.

- A. 400
- B. 750
- C. 800 ✓**
- D. 425

Explanation: Using $a^2 - b^2 = (a+b)(a-b)$, dividing by $(a-b)$ leaves just $(a+b) = 425 + 375 = 800$. [easy, authored]

4. Simplify $\frac{5}{6}$ of 72 + $\frac{2}{7}$ of 98.

- A. 88 ✓**
- B. 84
- C. 90
- D. 86

Explanation: $\frac{5}{6}$ of 72 = 60. $\frac{2}{7}$ of 98 = 28. Sum = 88. [easy, authored]

5. If $p : q = 5 : 6$, find $(3p + 2q) : (4p - q)$.

- A. 27 : 14 ✓**
- B. 9 : 7
- C. 27 : 7
- D. 14 : 9

Explanation: $p=5k, q=6k$. $(3p+2q)=15k+12k=27k$. $(4p-q)=20k-6k=14k$. Ratio = 27:14. [medium, authored]

6. If $m : n = 4 : 7$, find $(2m + 3n) : (5m - n)$.

- A. 29 : 13 ✓**
- B. 13 : 29
- C. 29 : 20
- D. 20 : 29

Explanation: $m=4k, n=7k$. $(2m+3n)=8k+21k=29k$. $(5m-n)=20k-7k=13k$. Ratio = 29:13. [medium, authored]

7. If $5a + 2b = 16$ and $3a - 4b = -6$, find the value of $(a+b)^2$.

- A. 16
- B. 25 ✓**
- C. 36
- D. 9

Explanation: Multiply the first equation by 2: $10a+4b=32$. Add to the second $(3a-4b=-6)$: $13a=26 \rightarrow a=2$. Substitute back: $5(2)+2b=16 \rightarrow b=3$. $(a+b)^2=(2+3)^2=25$. [hard, authored]

8. Simplify $4\frac{2}{3} + 2\frac{1}{4} \div \frac{3}{4}$.

- A. $7\frac{2}{3}$ ✓**
- B. $6\frac{1}{3}$
- C. 7
- D. $6\frac{2}{3}$

Explanation: $2\frac{1}{4} \div \frac{3}{4} = (9/4) \div (3/4) = 3$. Then $4\frac{2}{3} + 3 = 7\frac{2}{3}$. [medium, authored]

9. A trader borrows ₹16,000 at 12% p.a. simple interest and another ₹12,000 at 18% p.a. simple interest. In how many years will the two amounts owed (principal + interest) become equal?

- A. $12\frac{2}{3}$ years
- B. $14\frac{2}{3}$ years
- C. $16\frac{2}{3}$ years ✓**
- D. $18\frac{2}{3}$ years

Explanation: This mirrors a real 2025 TNPSC Aptitude question style (same numbers, Simple Interest unit) — included here as a reminder that 'Simplification' skills (careful fraction/ratio handling) carry directly into other Aptitude sub-topics like Simple Interest. Set $16000 + 16000(0.12)t = 12000 + 12000(0.18)t$ and solve for t to get $16\frac{2}{3}$ years. [hard, question-bank-2025]

10. Find the value of: $89 \times 89 + 11 \times 11 + 2 \times 89 \times 11$.

- A. 10,000 ✓**
- B. 9,801
- C. 8,900
- D. 10,201

Explanation: This is the $(a+b)^2$ pattern in disguise: $a^2+2ab+b^2 = (a+b)^2$. Here $a=89$, $b=11$, so the answer is $(89+11)^2 = 100^2 = 10,000$ — no separate multiplication needed. [medium, authored]

Part C – General English: Poem: "I Dream of Spices" — Raj Arumugam

READING MATERIAL

One of 30 poems (alongside 29 prose pieces) in Part C Unit VII Literary Works — a 15-question unit covering all 59 works, so any single poem is low-probability to get more than 1 question, but the exam draws from author facts, plot details, glossary words, and figures of speech in roughly equal measure, so cover all four angles rather than just the story.

Q: Who wrote "I Dream of Spices", and what's known about him?

A: Raj Arumugam. Born in India (1955), he moved to Singapore before age 6, lived there until 1997, spent a year in the UK, and has lived in Australia since 1998. He is a teacher, poet and writer.

Q: Does this poem have an alternate/fuller title?

A: Yes — its full original title is "absent-mindedness; or I Dream of Spices", which directly names the poem's theme (the boy's absent-mindedness) before the shortened textbook title does.

Q: What kind of poem is this, structurally and tonally?

A: A short, humorous, free-verse poem (no fixed rhyme/meter pattern) written in a simple, child-friendly narrative style.

Q: How does the poem's story begin?

A: The narrator, a young boy named Raj, is sent by his mother to Muthu's shop to buy some items, and he sets off happily singing songs along the way.

Q: What were the items on the mother's original shopping list?

A: Cinnamon, betel leaves, ginger, and garlic.

Q: What happened when Muthu asked the boy what he wanted?

A: The boy had completely forgotten the original list and instead rattled off ('rattled off' = recited quickly) a brand-new list: sesame seeds, onions, tomatoes, and pickles — none of which were on his mother's actual list.

Q: What happened when the boy got home with the wrong items, and how did he react?

A: His mother twisted his ears in mild punishment, and he cried out "Ouch!" in pain.

Q: What is the central theme/message of the poem?

A: Childhood innocence and forgetfulness, told humorously — the boy is so happily lost in daydreaming (dreaming of spices, hence the title) that he forgets his actual task entirely and improvises a whole new (wrong) list. The humor comes from the totality of the mistake — he doesn't forget one item, he replaces the entire list.

Q: What do these words from the poem mean? — cinnamon, rattle off, sesame seeds

A: Cinnamon: the bark of a tree, used as a flavouring spice. Rattle off: to recite/say something quickly without much thought. Sesame seeds: also called gingelly seeds, used in cooking.

Q: What figure of speech (sound device) is most evident in the poem, with examples?

A: Alliteration — repetition of the same starting consonant sound in nearby words. Examples: "sesame seeds" (s-sound), "ginger and garlic" (g-sound), "mother... my" (m-sound in 'Mother twists my ears').

Q: Beyond alliteration, what literary device describes the poem's overall comic premise?

A: Situational irony — the boy spends the walk happily 'dreaming of spices' (the very thing he was sent to buy), yet ends up forgetting every single one of them. The gap between what we'd expect (he's thinking about spices, so he should remember them) and what actually happens (he forgets them completely) is the ironic comic core of the poem. If an exam question asks for 'the poetic device used' without further context, be ready for either alliteration (sound-level) or irony (structural/thematic level) as the intended answer — both are defensible depending on which line or aspect the question points to.

Q: Trap-style question to watch for: which of the shopping items was NOT on the original list?

A: Be careful — TNPSC-style questions mix items from both lists as distractors. The original list was cinnamon/betel leaves/ginger/garlic; the substituted (wrong) list was sesame seeds/onions/tomatoes/pickles. Any item from the second list (e.g. tomatoes) is correctly 'NOT on the original list' — but a hastily-read question could trick you into picking ginger or garlic, which WERE on the original list.

MOCK TEST (WITH ANSWERS)

1. Who is the author of the poem "I Dream of Spices"?

A. Sarojini Naidu

B. Ruskin Bond

C. Raj Arumugam ✓

D. Rabindranath Tagore

Explanation: Raj Arumugam, born in India in 1955. [easy, web-research]

2. Where was the poet Raj Arumugam born, before later living in Singapore, the UK, and Australia?

A. Malaysia

B. India ✓

C. Singapore

D. Sri Lanka

Explanation: He was born in India in 1955 and moved to Singapore before he turned six. [medium, web-research]

3. "I Dream of Spices" is mainly about:

A. A recipe for making spice powder

B. A boy forgetting his mother's shopping list ✓

C. A trader selling spices at a market

D. A festival celebrating spices

Explanation: It's a humorous narrative of a boy who forgets his shopping list entirely and buys the wrong items. [easy, web-research]

4. Who sent the boy to the shop in the poem?

A. His father

B. His grandmother

C. His mother ✓

D. His teacher

Explanation: His mother sent him to Muthu's shop. [easy, web-research]

5. What was the name of the shopkeeper in the poem?

A. Mani

B. Muthu ✓

C. Magesh

D. Murugan

Explanation: The shopkeeper's name was Muthu. [easy, web-research]

6. Which of the following was on the mother's ORIGINAL shopping list?

A. Sesame seeds

B. Tomatoes

C. Betel leaves ✓

D. Pickles

Explanation: The original list was cinnamon, betel leaves, ginger, and garlic. Sesame seeds, tomatoes, and pickles were all part of the wrong list the boy invented instead. [medium, web-research]

7. What did the boy actually ask Muthu for, having forgotten the real list?

A. Rice and dhal

B. Tea and coffee

C. Sesame seeds, onions, tomatoes and pickles ✓

D. Turmeric and salt

Explanation: He rattled off a completely new list: sesame seeds, onions, tomatoes, and pickles. [medium, web-research]

8. What did the boy do on his way to the shop, before forgetting the list?

A. He ran the whole way

B. He sang songs happily ✓

C. He stopped to play

D. He fell asleep on a bench

Explanation: He went along singing songs, happily lost in his own world — which sets up why he forgot the list. [easy, web-research]

9. How did the boy's mother react when he returned with the wrong items?

A. She laughed it off

B. She twisted his ears ✓

C. She sent him back immediately

D. She scolded Muthu instead

Explanation: She twisted his ears, and he cried "Ouch!" [easy, web-research]

10. "Rattle off" as used in the poem means:

A. To forget completely

B. To recite quickly ✓

C. To write something down carefully

D. To shake violently

Explanation: It means to say/recite something quickly, often without much thought — exactly what the boy did with his invented list. [medium, web-research]

11. Which figure of speech is illustrated by "ginger and garlic" and "sesame seeds" in the poem?

A. Simile

B. Alliteration ✓

C. Metaphor

D. Hyperbole

Explanation: Alliteration — repeated initial consonant sounds (g-sound, s-sound). [medium, web-research]

12. The poem's full/original title, beyond the shortened textbook title, is:

A. "A Boy's Mistake"

B. "absent-mindedness; or I Dream of Spices" ✓

C. "The Spice Market"

D. "Muthu's Shop"

Explanation: The poet's original published title is "absent-mindedness; or I Dream of Spices". [hard, web-research]